

Lexar SD/CF card USB 3.0 reader

Lexar has come out with a dual-slot SD / CF card reader that uses USB 3.0 technology for transferring image and videos, priced around \$50

NEC's dual screen tablet

Life Touch W, the tablet announced by NEC at CES will start shipping in Japan this June onwards. It houses a Cortex A8 CPU, 384 MB RAM and two 800x600 resistive touchscreens

Canon 1D Mark 4

Who needs a full frame?

On one side we have an indisputably superb crop professional body; on the other, the fact that it is priced at nearly double the price of full frame body. The Mark 4 is an interesting option on account of this, and despite its performance, a camera that can only be recommended to a select niche of professionals. The Mark 4 is a full-size, integrated vertical grip body designed for the professional, and the magnesium alloy body, solid grip, moisture and dust sealing are all givens at this level. The Mark 4 is a tank, built for desert and Antarctic alike, although it's lighter than the Nikon D3s, and has a less luxurious, slightly harder rubber grip. All flaps and buttons are moisture sealed too, and this sealing is a cut above the

sealing on the impressive (in this regard) EOS 7D. The sensor is an APS-H, larger than the APS-C variant, with a crop factor of 1.3x compared to a full frame. Some rationalise its existence to Canon's inability to manage more than 6 fps from a full frame sensor, meaning sports and wildlife photographers would go the Nikon route, not out of choice, but necessity.

As is common for vertical grip DSLRs, the body has two status LCDs. The rear one is pretty useless unless you intend to look at it while spinning dials. The top one however, has all the necessary visual cues needed when changing settings. The layout of buttons on the rear is radically different from other Canon bodies like the EOS 7D and 5Dmk2. The most glaring difference is the lack of the vertical strip of buttons on the left side of the main LCD. These buttons are now clustered on the top of the body, above the LCD and even beneath it. This is not bad, but it takes getting used to, and we don't like the fact that it involves more movement of the left hand to reach various buttons. We miss the lack of a dedicated one touch RAW button. The memory card bay supports dual cards, one CF and one SD.

The 45-point, autofocus system with 39 cross type points and 6 assist points is a serious step up from the EOS 5Dmk2, but the 7D with its

sparser points remains equally versatile in terms of selection of focus clusters. The Mark 4 focuses instantly in good light and mediocre light, and a bit slower in dim light, where it needs to rely on contrast, the speed is lens depending, and with a 50mm f1.2, we found the Mark 4 quite fast at night shooting even silhouettes and statues with little contrast although it



on Canon with their stronger noise reduction, noise shows up as artifacts more than grain. At ISO12800, the D3s takes the lead and maintains this, obviously on account of its huge sensor, but the fact that the Mark 4 holds up till ISO 6400 itself is quite commendable. In bright daylight and low ISO shooting, the Mark 4 produces a more detailed output than the D3s, noticeable if both images are viewed are viewed at the same size. What is really heartening is that JPEGs have a great deal of highlighting, and lots of detail – most pro bodies are notorious for giving greatly improved output by shooting in space hungry RAW mode, and the Mark 4 bucks this most unwelcome trend.

If the benefits of a crop sensor like greater corner sharpness, less vignette and of course a longer zoom with any lens appeals to you as a pro shooter, then the Mark 4 will satisfy. If you're a sports photographer or shooting wildlife, the high fps coupled with the low light ability of the Mark 4 should be right up your alley. It is more versatile than the D3s for shooting in good light and at base ISOs will produce a larger image and hence larger usable prints. However, if you want absolutely the best low light performance, it is still the Nikon D3s. For ₹2,59,995 for the body, the Mark 4 is not cheap, and you could easily pick up a Nikon D700 or Canon 5Dmk2 for half the price and of course with less than half the speed.

Michael Browne

Specifications

APS-H; resolution: 16.1-megapixels; sensor size: 27.9 mm x 18.6 mm; Video resolution: 1920 x 1080p; battery: 2,300 mAh; weight: 1230 grams

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Price: ₹2,59,995

8.5
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Features.....8.0
Performance.....8.5
Build Quality8.5
Value for money6.0